# HOW BJP WON DELHI

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's address to the cadre on February 8 had more fervour than usual. After all, the party had returned to power in the national capital after 27 years, winning 48 seats in Delhi's 70-member assembly and 45.6 per cent of its popular vote. What made it sweeter was that it was a long-aspired-for moral victory over the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), with its bossman Arvind Kejriwal himself trounced by the BJP's Parvesh Verma. This is also a third endorsement of the party's new election template, after Haryana and Maharashtra. The next set of assembly polls begin with Bihar later this year. The BJP is expected to borrow lots from the Delhi campaign. The highlights:




**BACK IN POWER** BJP workers at the party HQ in Delhi after the win, Feb. 8

ARUN KUMAR

**Strategic use of Brand Modi:** PM Modi's speeches criticised the Delhi government and the AAP leadership, using terms like *'AAP-da'* (disaster) and *'sheeshmahal'* (glass palace, referring to the crores spent on renovations to the CM's bungalow) but stopped short of naming Kejriwal. He also avoided directly evoking divisive agendas, leaving it to the local leaders.

**Controlling the narrative:** The party took a 'grid-like' approach, restricted the conversation to local issues and lack of delivery on promises. And while they attacked Kejriwal's policies, they didn't fall for AAP's attempts to draw them into debates about freebies or personal attacks on the ex-CM.

**Target Kejriwal:** Realising there was anti-incumbency against Kejriwal, the BJP fielded their strongest candidate, the late ex-CM Sahib Singh Verma's son Parvesh Verma, against him. The sniper attacks focused on showing how the AAP leader had become the antithesis of the champion of change he was during his activist days.

**The RSS factor:** In August '24, the RSS deployed their north India in-charge Jatin Kumar to lay the ground in the national capital. The RSS frontal organisations held some 61,000 meetings across the 70 seats. RSS volunteers were active in the slums and JJ clusters.

**Soft Hindutva:** For Delhi, the BJP top leadership largely avoided the "*katenge to batenge*" narrative, though Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath's rally made some noise on those lines. This helped the party minimise polarisation among the Muslims. It also helped that Kejriwal took their vote for granted and didn't campaign as much in Muslim-dominated pockets. In fact, the BJP made some inroads in seats where Muslims were a deciding factor (over 30 per cent share). In 10 such seats, the BJP won three—Mustafabad, Rithala and Shahdara.

**SIFTING THROUGH ITS DATA, THE BJP IDENTIFIED A 16 PER CENT 'FLOATING VOTE' AND ZEROED IN ON THEM**

**Data IQ:** The BJP entered the campaign with one revealing statistic: it got roughly 50 per cent vote share in Delhi in each Lok Sabha poll (2014, 2019 and 2024) but this would slip in every subsequent assembly poll. In the 2024 LS election, 50 per cent of Delhi's middle class backed the BJP; only 32 per cent voted AAP. Sifting through the data, the BJP think-tank identified a 16 per cent 'floating vote' and zeroed in on them across 3,900 of the total 13,900 booths. Teams of booth workers were deployed to identify roughly 300,000 people perceived as the 'floating vote'. In the final week of the campaign, they were aggressively pursued. "Many of these voters were not averse to supporting the BJP, and PM Modi did appeal to them. Our estimate is that half of them came out on polling day and voted for us," says a party strategist. ■